



PHOTO BY **BANDEEP SINGH**

MAN WITH A PLAN Adar Poonawalla, CEO, SII

Key Highlights

- ❶ Adar Poonawalla took the reins at Serum Institute of India as CEO in 2011
- ❷ SII's Covishield was the first Covid-19 vaccine in India to receive emergency use approval for public use
- ❸ SII, which had a turnover of ₹5,238 crore in FY19, saw a stupendous surge to ₹7,201 crore of turnover in 2020-21
- ❹ SII manufactures nearly 1.5 billion doses of vaccines each year
- ❺ Under Poonawalla, Serum Institute of India now marks its presence in 171 countries, including regulated markets such as Canada and the UK

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strumental in the launch of SII's oral polio vaccine that has been its bestseller.

People who work closely with him have nothing but praise for his leadership and support. Parag Deshmukh, Director of International Business, SII, takes a cue from American basketball coach John Wooden's book *Pyramid of Success*. On the right-hand side, besides patience, there are four additional aspects—integrity, reliability, honesty and sincerity. "By that very definition, Poonawalla is a leader who embodies all of these qualities together, professionally as well as personally," he says. "I joined SII in 2007 and over the decade, I have witnessed him transform the face of global vaccine manufacturing with his undeterred commitment, strong resolve and the willingness to go beyond the bare necessity."

Poonawalla is respectful towards his employees and fosters a positive and conducive work environment. This usually means no long working hours unless you are trying to save the world in the middle of a pandemic. He in-

stills confidence amongst his colleagues and encourages them to trust their judgement on operational decisions. "It has resulted in SII achieving several milestones in the industry. One of the crucial things is our presence across 171 nations—especially our foray into regulated markets such as Canada, the UK, and some other developed countries," says Deshmukh.

In today's time, it is important for business leaders to adapt to a rapidly evolving environment. Poonawalla is someone who realises that. He is aware that one can't always deal with difficult situations with a set playbook. "To me, Poonawalla is someone who sets the benchmark of true leadership. His approach to business with compassion and thoughtfulness is aligned with the philosophy of the Serum Institute of India. More than a businessman, he is a change-maker—trailblazing and redefining the essence of business for good," says Deshmukh. **BT**

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